Lesson 06: Writing a Formal Email

English Stage 1 (B1) · Unit 1: People and Places

Adapted from People and Places - An Intermediate Integrated-Skills Module for English Learners by Sara Ferguson, Grossmont College (CC BY-NC-SA 4.0): 1.1: Writing A Formal Email; 1.2: Traditional Paragraph Structure and Email Etiquette; 1.3: Assignment: Writing a Formal Email.

In this lesson

You will learn what a good formal email needs, read the short composition "Email Etiquette" and study the parts of a traditional paragraph. Then you will write an email that introduces you, with a self-introduction attached.

Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Write a clear and specific subject line.
- Choose a polite greeting and closing for different readers.
- Find the title, topic sentence and concluding sentence of a paragraph.
- Use signal words (First, Second, Third, Finally) to find the main points and take notes.
- Write a formal email with an attachment.

Key language

Word or phrase	Meaning in simple English	Example
subject line	the short line that says what the email is about	Question about test - ESL 103
greeting	the words at the start of the email	Dear Professor Simons,
closing	the polite words at the end, before your name	Sincerely,
attach	add a file (an essay, a picture, a video) to an email	I have attached my essay to this email.
CC	send a copy to a person who needs the information but does not need to answer	I send the email TO my professor, but I CC the tutor in the class.
BCC	send to many people without showing their names	BCC is mostly used for business emails.
etiquette	rules for polite behavior	"Email Etiquette"
concise	short and clear	"Question About Homework" is clear and concise.
proofread	read your writing again to find and fix mistakes	You took the time to proofread your email.
pleasantry	a short, friendly sentence after the greeting	A pleasantry makes the tone friendly and polite.

Rules and explanations

What a good email has

- **A clear and specific subject line** that says the reason for the email, for example "Absence - ESL 103".
- **A greeting.** You know the person: "Dear Mr. / Ms. / Professor [family name]," or "Hello [name]," or "Hi [name],". You do not know who will read it: "Dear Sir or Madam," or "To Whom It May Concern:". Use the reader's title (Professor, Mr., Ms.) with the family name, unless the reader asks you not to. "Hi Mark!" is only for a good friend.
- **A closing + your full name (signature):** Sincerely, / Thank you, / Regards, / Best, / Thank you for your time, / Thank you for your help, then for example "Jaquelin Yang".
- **Capital letters and punctuation.** Do not write in ALL CAPITALS (the reader thinks you are shouting) or use too many exclamation marks. Start every sentence and every proper noun with a capital letter.
- **Spelling and grammar.** No abbreviations like LOL, TTYL, THX. Read your email again before you send it.
- **Also:** use a professional email address. No emojis. If you attach a file, say so in the email.

How to organize the email

1. Identify yourself: full name and class.
2. Give a pleasantry (one or two friendly sentences).
3. State the reason for writing, with background information if necessary.
4. Thank the reader and add a short closing.

Many questions? Make a list, so the reader answers all of them. Leave an empty line between the parts. Keep it short.

Traditional paragraph structure

- **Title:** the name of the composition.
- **Topic sentence:** near the start; it gives the main idea.
- **Concluding sentence:** the last sentence; it finishes the paragraph and often repeats the main idea.
- **Signal words** (First, Second, Third, Finally) introduce the points in order.

> **Note for Arabic speakers**
>
> - Arabic script has no capital letters, so they are easy to forget in English. Check every sentence start, every name, and the word "I".
> - Arabic writing often joins many ideas with "and" in one long sentence. In an English email, short sentences are clearer.

Practice

1. Subject lines. Which are good? Why are the others bad?

- a) Hellooooo (with a smiley face)
- b) EMERGENCY URGENT TEACHER PLS RESPOND!!!
- c) Absence - ESL 103
- d) Question about test - ESL 103
- e) Help!
- Now write a clear subject line for: f) an email to your landlord about a housing problem; g) an email to a shop about a problem with online shopping.

2. Greetings. Choose the best greeting for:

- a) a good friend: Dear Mark! / Hi Mark! / Mr. Mark Thompson! / Hi there!
- b) a college professor I know: Dear Sir, / Mr. John, / Hello Professor Smith, / Dear John,
- c) a female professor: Dear teacher, / Dear Ms. Simons, / Hello Miss! / Dear Professor Simons,
- d) a new business contact, and I do not know his or her name: Dear Sir, / Dear Mister, / Hello! / Dear Sir or Madam,

3. What is wrong?

- a) TEACHER I WILL BE LATE TODAY!!!!!!!!!!
- b) LOL TTYL THX
- c) happiiiteacherrr@gmail.com
- d) I will be late today (sad face) sorry (sad face)

4. Attach, CC or BCC?

- a) You send your essay with the email.
- b) You write to your professor; the class tutor needs the information but does not need to answer.
- c) You send one email to many people and do not want to show their names.

5. "Email Etiquette." Read the composition in your lesson material (section 1.2).

- a) In the first paragraph, underline and label the title, the topic sentence and the concluding sentence.
- b) What is the topic of the composition? How do you know?
- c) What is the purpose of the first paragraph? (to show how to write an effective email / to define email etiquette / to explain why email etiquette is important / to give more information about emails)
- d) What is the purpose of the second paragraph? Choose from the same list.
- e) What signal words introduce the four tips? How many sentences does the author write for each tip?
- f) Write notes about the four tips: key words only, not sentences.

Speak with your tutor

- "You are my professor. I will read my email to you. Tell me if my greeting, pleasantry and closing are polite enough."
- "Name a person I must write to: a friend, a professor, a company I do not know. I will say the best greeting and closing. Correct me."
- "Ask me questions for my self-introduction: languages, why I study, English goals, hobbies. One question at a time."
- "Let me explain the four tips from 'Email Etiquette' in my own words. Tell me if I miss anything."

Read aloud

1. ET·i·quette
2. pro·FES·sion·al
3. con·CISE
4. punc·tu·A·tion
5. SIG·na·ture
6. at·TACH·ment
7. sin·CERE·ly
8. How then can we write professional and clear emails? (↘)
9. I have attached my essay to this email. (↘)

Writing task

Write a formal email to introduce yourself, with your self-introduction attached. Send it to a teacher, or write it to your AI tutor as if the tutor is your professor.

- **Email:** a short, specific subject line, then the four parts in "How to organize the email". Say that the self-introduction is attached.
- **Self-introduction:** 1 or 2 paragraphs, typed in Word (.doc or .docx) or similar. Give details that are useful for your professor: your country, languages, family, why you study, English goals, past school experiences, interests and hobbies. Check grammar and spelling.
- **To attach:** save the document, open a new email, click "Attachment" (often a paperclip), find the document and click "Open."
- **Points (20):** subject line 1; greeting and pleasantry 2; identity and purpose 4; closing 1; self-introduction 12. Ask your tutor to score your email.

Example (example answer):

> Subject: Self-introduction - ESL 103
>
> Dear Professor Yang,

> I hope you are having a good week. My name is [your full name], and I am a student in your ESL 103 class. I am writing to introduce myself. I have attached my self-introduction to this email.
>
> Thank you for your time.
>
> Sincerely, [your full name]

Watch online

- Useful email phrases (the book's link): https://www.usingenglish.com/articles/100-most-useful-emailing-phrases.html
- Grammar and phrases for emails, PDF (the book's link): https://www.usingenglish.com/files/pdf/emailing-phrases-tenses-and-verb-forms-review.pdf
- More instructions for business emails, British Council (the book's link): https://learnenglish.britishcouncil.org/en/english-emails

Answer key

1. Good: c and d. a) not clear or professional; b) all capitals, an abbreviation (PLS), too many exclamation marks; e) not clear, sounds like an emergency (book). f) Broken heater in my apartment; g) Wrong item in my order (example answer).
2. a) Hi Mark! b) Hello Professor Smith, c) Dear Professor Simons, d) Dear Sir or Madam, (book). "Mr. John" and "Dear John" use a first name; "Dear Sir," is for a man you do not know; a professor's title is "Professor".
3. a) all capitals and too many exclamation marks; b) abbreviations; c) not a professional email address; d) emojis (book).
4. a) attach b) CC c) BCC (book).
5. "Email Etiquette":
    - a) Title: "Email Etiquette". Topic sentence: "The way we write emails is essential to being an effective communicator." (It gives the main idea. The first sentence, "Email is used in almost all aspects of life ...", introduces the topic; some teachers count the first two sentences together as the topic sentence.) Concluding sentence: "Therefore, we must be careful to write emails that are professional, polite, and clear."
    - b) Email etiquette: how to write polite, professional emails. The title and the first paragraph tell us.
    - c) to explain why email etiquette is important.
    - d) to show how to write an effective email.
    - e) First, Second, Third, Finally. Tip 1: 4 sentences; tip 2: 6; tip 3: 3; tip 4: 3.
    - f) (example answer) 1. subject line: reason, concise. 2. no all capitals; punctuation; proofread. 3. clear reason, not too much. 4. "thank you"; polite = reader helps.

My notes